Cinematography: Shots

What is Cinematography?

Rachel Morrison, the first woman Oscar-nominated for cinematography, on the set of *Mudbound*

Cinematography is the process of capturing moving images on film or a digital storage device. The word comes to us from three Greek roots—*kinesis*, meaning “movement”; *photo*, meaning “light”; and *graphia*, meaning “writing”—but the word was coined only after motion pictures themselves were invented. Cinematography is closely related to still photography, but its methods and technologies clearly distinguish it from its static predecessor. The cinematographer (also known as the director of photography, or DP) uses the camera as an expressive instrument. To make an informed analysis of a movie, we need to evaluate precisely how (and how well) the cinematographer, in collaboration with the other creative and technical contributors to the production, has harnessed the many aspects of her craft to express story, mood, and meaning.